

Low Plurality Winner (LPW) Data Sources

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Background

The `recent_lpw` variable flags whether a locale's state had a statewide race (governor or U.S. senator) won with less than 40% of the vote within 10 years prior to the RCV ballot measure. The two cases in this study:

- **Maine:** Governor Paul LePage won in 2010 with 37.6% ([Ballotpedia](#))
- **Alaska:** Senator Lisa Murkowski won in 2010 with 39.7% (write-in) ([Ballotpedia](#))

The winner-share table behind `recent_lpw` is **derived programmatically** from downloadable returns (fetched by `R/00_download.R`, derived in the `recent_lpw` section of `R/01_clean_and_merge.R`):

Races	Source
U.S. Senate, all 6 states	MEDSL U.S. Senate 1976–2020 (statewide totals)
Governor, 5 county states	Amlani & Algara county returns 1865–2020, summed to state
Governor, Alaska 2014 & 2018	Official AK statewide summaries (Internet Archive)
Governor, Alaska 2010	Hand-entered (<code>statewide_elections_manual.csv</code>) — no machine-readable source exists

An earlier version of this project used a fully hand-extracted table (`data/raw/statewide_elections_lpw_2006_2018.csv`, copied from Ballotpedia and Wikipedia). That file is retained only as a cross-check: the pipeline stops if the derived LPW classification ever disagrees with it.

U.S. Senate returns (MEDSL)

- **Citation:** MIT Election Data and Science Lab, 2017, “U.S. Senate 1976–2020”, <https://doi.org/10.7910/DVN/PEJ5QU>, Harvard Dataverse
- **File:** `data/raw/medsl_senate_1976_2020.csv`
- **Download:** Harvard Dataverse API, file ID 7609736 (see `R/00_download.R`)

Senate races won with < 40% (2006+)

```
library(dplyr)

sen <- read.csv("../data/raw/medsl_senate_1976_2020.csv")

senate_winners <- sen %>%
  filter(stage == "gen", writein == "False") %>%
  group_by(year, state, state_po, totalvotes) %>%
  summarise(winner_votes = max(candidatevotes), .groups = "drop") %>%
  mutate(winner_share = round(100 * winner_votes / totalvotes, 1))

senate_winners %>%
```

```
filter(winner_share < 40, year >= 2006) %>%
arrange(winner_share) %>%
select(year, state, winner_share) %>%
knitr::kable(caption = "U.S. Senate races won with < 40% (2006+)")
```

Table 1: U.S. Senate races won with < 40% (2006+)

year	state	winner_share
2016	LOUISIANA	26.8
2020	GEORGIA	32.9
2010	ALASKA	35.6

Alaska 2010 appears at 35.6% — this is Joe Miller’s plurality among non-write-in candidates. Murkowski’s write-in share was 39.7%. Either way, no candidate cleared 40%, confirming the LPW classification.

Governor returns (Amlani & Algara)

MEDSL does not publish a consolidated governor returns file, but a county-level gubernatorial returns dataset covering 1865–2020 is available on Harvard Dataverse and aggregates cleanly to statewide totals.

- **Citation:** Amlani, Sharif; Algara, Carlos, 2021, Replication Data for “Partisanship & Nationalization in American Elections: Evidence from Presidential, Senatorial, & Gubernatorial Elections in the U.S. Counties, 1872–2020” (*Electoral Studies*), <https://doi.org/10.7910/DVN/DGUMFI>, Harvard Dataverse
- **File:** data/raw/gubernatorial_county_returns_1865_2020.RData (loads as gov_elections_release)
- **Download:** Harvard Dataverse API, file ID 5028535 (see R/00_download.R)

Two limitations, both handled in the pipeline:

1. **Alaska is absent** — the state has no counties. Alaska governor races come from official Division of Elections files instead (next section).
2. Only Democratic and Republican raw votes are itemized (plus an all-candidate total), so winner share is computed as $\max(D, R) / \text{total}$. This is correct whenever the winner was a D or R — true for every governor race in the five county states during the study window. Independent *losers* (e.g. Cutler, Maine 2010) are in the denominator and only shrink the computed winner share, the conservative direction for a < 40% flag.

```
load("../data/raw/gubernatorial_county_returns_1865_2020.RData")

state_po_map <- c(CA = "California", CO = "Colorado", ME = "Maine",
                 MA = "Massachusetts", MN = "Minnesota")

gov_winners <- gov_elections_release %>%
  filter(state %in% names(state_po_map), election_year >= 2006) %>%
  group_by(state, election_year) %>%
  summarise(dem = sum(democratic_raw_votes, na.rm = TRUE),
            rep = sum(republican_raw_votes, na.rm = TRUE),
            total = sum(raw_county_vote_totals, na.rm = TRUE),
            .groups = "drop") %>%
  mutate(winner_share = round(100 * pmax(dem, rep) / total, 1))

gov_winners %>%
  select(state, election_year, winner_share) %>%
  arrange(state, election_year) %>%
  knitr::kable(caption = "Governor winner shares, study states (2006+)")
```

Table 2: Governor winner shares, study states (2006+)

state	election_year	winner_share
CA	2006	55.9
CA	2010	53.8
CA	2014	60.0
CA	2018	61.9
CO	2006	57.0
CO	2010	51.1
CO	2014	49.3
CO	2018	53.4
MA	2006	55.6
MA	2010	48.4
MA	2014	48.4
MA	2018	66.6
ME	2006	38.1
ME	2010	38.1
ME	2014	48.2
ME	2018	50.8
MN	2006	46.7
MN	2010	43.6
MN	2014	50.1
MN	2018	53.8

Maine 2006 (38.1%) and 2010 (38.1%) are the only sub-40% governor races — matching the hand-extracted table (38.11% and 37.6%; the small 2010 difference reflects a different vote-total base, on the same side of 40%).

Alaska governor races

The Alaska Division of Elections publishes machine-readable statewide results summaries, but the live site now sits behind a CAPTCHA, so `R/00_download.R` fetches the Internet Archive’s captures of the official `results.txt` files:

- **2014:** `data/raw/alaska_statewide_results_2014.txt` (Walker/Mallott, an independent ticket, won with 48.1% — a case the two-party county dataset could not have handled)
- **2018:** `data/raw/alaska_statewide_results_2018.txt` (Dunleavy won with 51.4%)

2010 is the one race with no machine-readable source anywhere. The official 2010 results file — in every archived form (txt, htm, pdf) — contains only the U.S. Senate race (the Miller/Murkowski write-in count), and OpenElections’ Alaska coverage starts in 2014. The official record for the rest of the 2010 ballot is the set of per-district SOVC PDFs. This single row (Parnell, R, 59.06% — far above the 40% threshold) is hand-entered in `data/raw/statewide_elections_manual.csv` with its source documented inline.

Cross-check against the hand-extracted table

```
hand <- read.csv("../data/raw/statewide_elections_lpw_2006_2018.csv",
                 fileEncoding = "UTF-8-BOM")

hand %>%
  filter(Winner.Share.... < 40) %>%
  select(State, Year, Office, Winner.Share....) %>%
  knitr::kable(caption = "Hand-extracted table: races won with < 40%")
```

Table 3: Hand-extracted table: races won with $< 40\%$

State	Year	Office	Winner.Share....
Maine	2010	Governor	37.60
Maine	2006	Governor	38.11
Alaska	2010	Senator	39.70

Both the derived table and the hand-extracted table classify exactly **Maine and Alaska** as LPW states. `R/01_clean_and_merge.R` asserts this agreement with `stopifnot()` on every run.

Expanding to new locales

Adding a state now requires no hand extraction for any senate race (MEDSL, through 2020) or any governor race in a county state (Amlani & Algara, through 2020). Newer races would need the successor MEDSL releases or state sources; genuinely unsourceable races go in `statewide_elections_manual.csv` with a documented source.